The Finnish Basketball Development Model — Brief

Coaching philosophy and coach education of Suomen Koripalloliitto

A companion to the Swedish brief. Finland is often listed alongside Sweden as a federation that "went ecological," but its own model is a different animal — read the framing note first.

Framing note: not the same kind of thing as Sweden's

The Swedish framework is a single, published document explicitly built on **ecological dynamics and the constraints-led approach (CLA)**. The Finnish model is **not** primarily branded that way. It is a homegrown **coaching philosophy and coach-education system**, shaped over ~20 years of strategic processes by the Finnish Basketball Federation (Suomen Koripalloliitto), and grounded in **socio-constructivist learning** and **konseptiajattelu** ("concept thinking").

Ecological dynamics, nonlinear pedagogy, and CLA *do* live in Finland — but mostly in the **academic sport-pedagogy tradition** (Jyväskylä; Sami Kalaja, Timo Jaakkola) that feeds Finnish coach education generally, rather than as the basketball federation's named foundation. So when a source says "Finland also adopted the ecological approach," treat it as *directionally* true (decision-making, reading the game, representative practice are all there) but not as "Finland copied the Swedish eco-D/CLA framework." The Finnish emphasis is more **pedagogical and humanistic** than **motor-learning-theoretical**.

Key figure: **Jyri Lohikoski** — youth national-team coach since 2004 and coach educator, with a master's in education (classroom teacher training, University of Helsinki). Much of the public articulation of the model comes through him.

The conceptual core: three perceptions, three levels

Finnish basketball talks, at a conceptual level, about three "käsitykset" (perceptions/conceptions) mapped onto the relationships in any coaching situation:

- **Ihmiskäsitys** (human conception) — between **coach and player**.
- **Oppimiskäsitys** (learning conception) — between **player and game**.
- **Pelikäsitys** (game conception) — between **coach and game**.

Lohikoski frames every coaching moment as three levels: **the game, the player, the coaching.** The coach can never affect the game directly (the coach scores no baskets) — so the coach's intervention **always goes through the player**. Therefore the person comes first, and coaching is deeply **people-oriented**. Pedagogical, interpersonal, and leadership skills are treated as central, not soft extras.

"US before ME" — the value base

Finnish basketball is understood "first and foremost as a team game," where **US comes before ME**. The common goal drives the individual goal: a struggling individual is carried by shared trust and shared play, and that same security lets the individual dare to fulfil their role more boldly. Community spirit, team play, and helping others are explicit central values — and they shape the learning concept too.

The honest strategic backstory: Finland is small, with relatively few exceptional individual talents, so the federation concluded — by analysis — that **"individuality is not a competitive advantage; we do better by assisting more."** The collaborative model is partly a values choice and partly a deliberate response to a small talent pool and a hard-working, cooperative national culture.

“Hyvä harjoitus” = lämpö + laatu

The recurring image is the **good practice / the good moment** where player, game, and coaching meet. It is built from two parts:

- **LÄMPÖ (warmth):** humanity, consideration, empathy, caring, interaction, community, tolerance.
- **LAATU (quality):** learning, teaching, coaching, demand level, encouragement, and content — skills, tactics, strategies.

Warmth without quality limits development (“if you have nothing to offer as a coach, the interaction stays limited”); quality without warmth misses the person. Both are required. This pairs with the idea of **didactic competence** — strong subject-matter expertise *plus* people-orientation.

Konseptiajattelu (concept thinking)

Because basketball is a **multi-structured game** — phases, roles, tasks, required skills and qualities constantly mixing and changing — coach education teaches the game’s concepts **multi-structurally**: a single training weekend touches *all* the concepts the game needs, rather than isolating one.

For clarity of study, the concepts are split into **four main categories**:

1. **Yhteen pelaamisen taidot** — skills of playing together.
2. **Urheilijan taidot ja ominaisuudet** — the athlete’s skills and qualities.
3. **Valmentajan taidot** — the coach’s skills.
4. **Oppijan ja ajattelijan taidot** — the learner’s and thinker’s skills.

These break down into roughly **nine sub-categories** that function as the “subjects” of coach education.

“The game is always the same” — concepts recur, deepened over time

Finnish basketball pushes back on the linear “player pathway / game-structure ladder”: **“the game of basketball is always the same — we attack and defend, and the game goes around the same way; certain things only stand out more at different ages and levels.”** Lohikoski reaches for a loose metaphor here — *“if you want to use a metaphor, it’s more of a spiral”* — and the same concepts recur across the coach-education levels (I–III), deepened each time rather than introduced once and left behind. The classroom mechanism is konseptiajattelu: **all** the game’s concepts appear in a single training weekend, not one isolated topic at a time.

Don’t over-read the “spiral.” It’s Lohikoski’s informal image for “everything is connected and keeps coming back,” not a defined cyclic/loop structure — so I shouldn’t have drawn it as one. The substantive claim underneath is just the **integrated, recurring curriculum**: concepts are taught together and revisited at progressively greater depth, rather than introduced once and ticked off. Both federations share the spirit of “teach the concepts together, not in isolation”; the spiral is only Finland’s verbal way of saying it.

Pelikäsitys (game understanding)

Pelikäsitys is a broad whole that **shows up in the game as the solutions a player makes** — the ability to solve the game’s basic situations (1v1, 2v1, 3v2…) with and without the ball. Boiled down: **a player’s ability to advance the team’s winning.** It splits into three:

- **Pelin ymmärtäminen** (understanding the game) — internalising the game’s aims and the team’s cooperation principles; acting in the four game-situation roles per the team’s style; relating one’s own skills and physical qualities to the solution a situation demands.
- **Pelin lukeminen** (reading the game) — constant perception of the environment; quickly separating the sensory information relevant to the decision; helped by knowing in advance which visual cues to react to.
- **Ratkaisunteko** (decision-making / solving) — making the appropriate choice, then executing it; this is why **sport-technical skill has to be good enough to keep the eyes**

up on the play rather than down on the ball.

A theoretical caveat — and a correction. This three-step "understand → read → decide" structure — perceive the environment, separate the relevant cues, *pre-know which signals to react to*, then decide and execute — is essentially an **information-processing / cognitivist** account of skill: a perceive → interpret → decide → act chain with internal representations and a stored "experience bank." In a strict ecological-dynamics reading that is *not* how skill works — there, perception and action are **coupled**, affordances are perceived directly and invite action without a separate compute/decide stage, and you wouldn't drill a stored library of "cues to react to."

But here's the catch (this is where I earlier overstated the contrast): the Swedish framework's *own* decision-making model is the **same IP structure**. Its **BESLUTSFATTANDE** page lays out four components — **SKANNA → TOLKA → BESLUTA → AKTION** (scan → interpret → decide → act) — and explicitly says varied, game-like training builds up an **"erfarenhetsbank"** (experience bank) the player draws on. That is textbook information-processing, complete with internal representation. So decision-making is **not** a Finland-vs-Sweden divide: *both* describe it cognitively. Sweden simply draws its four components as an **overlapping Venn** (suggesting they interact rather than run in a strict pipeline), while Finland lists pelikäsitys as understand/read/decide.

The honest picture: Sweden brands the *overall framework* ecological/CLA (representative design, constraints, "keep it together," the five golden principles) but **reverts to information-processing language the moment it gets concrete about decision-making** — a common and well-known inconsistency in applied "ecological" frameworks. Finland never claimed eco-D for pelikäsitys in the first place. So on decision-making specifically, the two are closer than the branding implies; the real difference is at the level of stated *foundations* (eco-D/CLA vs socio-constructivist pedagogy), not in how each actually talks about reading and deciding.

The coach's job here is to support the player's **reflective competence**: help players analyse their own solutions and consequences across situations, not to dictate the answer.

Learning to learn, reflection, and the active athlete

The Finnish learning concept puts the **athlete's active role** and **oppimaan oppiminen** (learning to learn) at the centre, with **self-reflection** as the core mechanism. Practically: self-assessment, pair work, and small-group work; the conversational/dialogic coaching approach; long-term, reflexive learning that requires *change and new theoretical knowledge*, not just repetition of routines. The youth national teams have used the **Qridi Sport** app for years to run reflection, self-assessment, and independent-training programming.

How this maps onto the Swedish model

Theme	Sweden	Finland
Foundation	Ecological dynamics + CLA (explicit)	Socio-constructivism + konseptiajattelu (explicit); eco-D/NLP via the wider academic tradition
Headline framing	Four pillars + five golden principles	Three perceptions (ihmis-/oppimis-/pelikäsitys) + konseptiajattelu
Integrated/recurring curriculum (shared idea)	Concepts taught together, revisited across the development span + practice-time distribution pie	Konseptiajattelu: all concepts every session, deepened across levels I–III; "spiral" metaphor
Non-linearity of *development*	"Development is non-linear" (maturation, individual pace)	People-oriented, individualised; less formalised as a stated principle
How decision-making is actually described	BESLUTSFATTANDE Venn: scan → interpret → decide → act + "experience bank" — **information-processing**, despite the eco-D branding	Pelikäsitys: understand → read → decide — also **information-processing** / game-sense
Coach role	Designer of constraints; sparing instruction; self-evaluation	People-oriented "game teacher"; intervention goes through the player; reflective support
Centre of gravity	Motor-learning theory	Pedagogy + humanistic/team values ("US before ME")

The two arrive at overlapping practice (game-based, decision-rich, reflective, anti-early-set-plays) from **different stated starting points** — Sweden from skill-acquisition science, Finland from education theory and a team-first value system. But note the wrinkle above: when Sweden gets concrete about *decision-making*, it actually uses the same information-processing model Finland does, so the gap between them is narrower in practice than the eco-D-vs-pedagogy branding suggests.

Pointers to more info

Primary sources (Finnish Basketball Federation):

- Coaching of Finnish basketball — overview hub: https://www.basket.fi/basketball-finland/
- Coach education foundations ("kivijalat ja keskeiset periaatteet"): https://www.basket.fi/basket/korisperhe/valmentajalle/valmentajakoulutus/
- Coach-education structure and contents (konseptiajattelu, the four categories): https://www.basket.fi/infosivut/koulutusjarjestelma/

Commentary & interviews:

- "The success of the Finnish national basketball teams is the result of systematic work" — Jyri Lohikoski interview (Qridi Sport, 2022): https://www.qridisport.com/blog/the-success-of-the-finnish-national-basketball-teams-is-the-result-of-systematic-work
- "Pelikäsitys — mistä oikeastaan on kyse?" (Pääkallo.fi, 2015) — clear breakdown of pelikäsitys into understanding/reading/deciding: https://paakallo.fi/2015/09/blogi-pelikasitys-mista-oikeastaan-on-kyse/

The ecological / nonlinear strand in Finnish sport pedagogy (the academic feeder):

- Sami Kalaja, "Taitoharjoittelun uudet (vanhat) suunnat" — nonlinear pedagogy and constraints in Finnish skill training: https://docplayer.fi/25792568-Taitoharjoittelun-uudet-vanhat-suunnat-sami-kalaja.html
- Kalaja, S. & Jaakkola, T. — Finnish texts on motor-skill learning, ecological dynamics, and nonlinear pedagogy (standard references in Finnish coach education).

- University of Jyväskylä (JYU) theses applying ecological dynamics / CLA to Finnish team-sport coaching (e.g. football), which illustrate how the theory reaches Finnish practice.

Cross-reference: the Swedish brief in this folder, `swedish-basketball-development-model.md`, and the framework comparison above.